Q+A

BREAKING BARRIERS

*Malayalam actor **Shwetha Menon**, known for her roles in hits like* Salt n' Pepper *and* Paleri Manikyam: Oru Pathira-kolapathakathinte Katha, *on her historic appointment as the first female president of the Association of Malayalam Movie Actors (AMMA)*

Q. What does having broken this glass ceiling mean to you?

While I put in a lot of thought before filing my nomination, this aspect just didn't cross my mind. At no point did I think I'd be making history with this win. While I am getting a lot of love and affection from my community, I know this is a huge responsibility and I have my work cut out.

Q. Around the time you filed your nomination, there were some vicious attacks on you, including an FIR for acting in movies with 'vulgar content'. How did you deal with this?

It was very upsetting. But also, I knew I would be targeted. When someone tries to do something different, a lot of people immediately want to pull them down.

Q. What are the areas of concern within AMMA that you want to focus on?

For now, I am looking to better understand the issues that our 504 members are facing. There are two things that AMMA has been doing for years and I just want to make sure that these continue. First is *Kainettam*, an honorarium of Rs 5,000 that's given to many members. The second is medical insurance of Rs 5 lakh to artists above a certain age.

Q. And, work continues?

Absolutely. I am listening to some really interesting scripts right now. I had *Jangar*, a thriller, release about a month ago. Later this month, *Karam*, an action-thriller directed by Vineeth Sreenivasan, will be in theatres. I have a really interesting cameo in the film. What's keeping me busy right now is *Comedy Masters*, a reality talent show on Amrita TV. Shooting it is so much fun. I love being in front of the camera so much that any time I have an opportunity, I am very grateful.

—with Karishma Upadhyay

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Photograph by TOBIN JOSEPH